5

KAARTHIKEYAN WAS VISITING DELHI TO DEPOSE BEFORE THE VERMA Inquiry Commission. He had made it a point to visit Sonia Gandhi at 10, Janpath. Sonia could not hold in her tears. Her daughter Priyanka did most of the talking. Two years elder to her, Rahul Gandhi chose to hear the SIT chief debrief his mother on the progress of the investigation into his father's assassination.

The SIT was at working in a frenzy. Teams within teams were operating, as too many accused and suspects were being examined. They had to be seated across from each other and interrogated to check the veracity of their statements. And, above all, the SIT had to keep them safe. The judicial process was about to start. The investigation still had a long way to go.

If Raju and Kanth interrogated the accused, Ragothaman and Verma got busy decoding intercepted messages sourced from the intelligence agencies. And if Verma or Ragothaman took their turn at interrogating the suspects, Kaarthikeyan and Sri Kumar sat on the information sourced from the accused and analysed them threadbare. It brought out counter-questions too. And that brought out the story behind the assassination.

Another team of analysts and documentation staff went through tens and thousands of incriminating documents, literature, journals and photographs seized from various LTTE activists, cadres and sympathizers during raids across Tamil Nadu. The local police and 'Q' branch carried out raids whenever there were reports of any suspicious person or movements. Subsequently, they handed over the suspects to the SIT for further investigation.

In the meantime, Chandrasekharan's forensics team devised an electronic skull-identification method to identify the assassin with the help of earlier photographs of her, along with the skull and the head model of